

This Swimmer Just Keeps Getting Faster -- and He's Only a College Freshman!

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Have you ever tried to beat your own record in something like a video game high score or a race in the pool? Imagine doing it three times in one weekend! That's what Koby Bujak-Upton, a super-fast swimmer from the University of Tennessee, just did at the MAC Charlotte Open. Koby, who is only a college freshman, swam in three **sprint freestyle** events the 50, 100, and 200 meter races and set new **personal bests** in all of them. In the 50 free, he touched the wall in 22.90 seconds, shaving off three-tenths of a second from his old record. That might not sound like much, but in swimming, it's a huge leap! He also crushed his 100 free time (48.96 seconds) and his 200 free time (1:48.44). What makes this even cooler? Last season, Koby became the first freshman ever to swim the 200-yard freestyle in under 1 minute and 30 seconds a barrier only nine college swimmers in history have broken. He finished second at the **NCAA Championships** in that event. Now, he's heading to the **Australian Trials** in Sydney, where he'll race against his country's best for a spot on the national team. But Koby wasn't the only star in Charlotte. A 16-year-old named David Sammons also had an amazing meet, setting **personal bests** in the 200 **IM**, 400 **IM**, and **butterfly** events. His 200 fly time even ranks him as the 9th fastest 15-16 year old in U.S. history! It just goes to show: with hard work and a love for the water, you can keep getting faster one splash at a time.

Word Treasure

sprint freestyle -- Short-distance swimming races where you can use any stroke (usually front crawl).

personal bests -- The fastest time a swimmer has ever achieved in an event.

NCAA Championships -- The biggest tournament in U.S. college sports, run by the organization that governs college athletics.

Australian Trials -- A competition to choose which swimmers will represent Australia in international meets.

IM -- Short for Individual Medley, a race where a swimmer uses all four strokes (butterfly, backstroke, breaststroke, freestyle) in order.

butterfly -- A swimming stroke where both arms move together over the water, like a butterfly's wings.

Background you need

The NCAA (National Collegiate Athletic Association) runs college sports in the U.S., and its swimming championships are where the best young swimmers compete.

Koby Bujak-Upton is originally from Australia, so he must go through the Australian Trials in Sydney to earn a spot on the national team for events like the World Championships or Olympics.

David Sammons, still a high school student, is already breaking records that place him among the fastest swimmers in U.S. history for his age group.

Break it down

WHO: Koby Bujak-Upton, a freshman swimmer at the University of Tennessee, and David Sammons, a 16-year-old swimmer.

WHAT: Koby set personal bests in the 50, 100, and 200 meter freestyle at the MAC Charlotte Open, and David also broke his personal records.

WHERE: At the MAC Charlotte Open in Charlotte, North Carolina.

WHY: Koby is preparing for the Australian Trials to try out for his country's national team, hoping to compete internationally.

Why it matters

Koby's story shows that with practice and determination, you can beat your own records and move closer to big dreams, no matter how young you are.

Test what you remember

1. What university does Koby Bujak-Upton swim for?
 - (A) University of Tennessee
 - (B) University of Michigan
 - (C) Stanford
 - (D) University of Texas
2. In which three events did Koby set personal bests at the MAC Charlotte Open?
 - (A) 50, 100, and 200 meter freestyle
 - (B) 100, 200, and 400 IM
 - (C) 50, 100, and 200 butterfly
 - (D) 200, 400, and 800 freestyle
3. What historic barrier did Koby break last season in the 200-yard freestyle?
 - (A) Under 2 minutes
 - (B) Under 1:30
 - (C) Under 1:40
 - (D) Under 1:20
4. Where is Koby heading to try out for his national team?
 - (A) Charlotte
 - (B) London
 - (C) Sydney
 - (D) Tokyo
5. How old is David Sammons?
 - (A) 15
 - (B) 16
 - (C) 17
 - (D) 18
6. In which event did David Sammons rank 9th fastest in U.S. history for his age group?
 - (A) 200 IM
 - (B) 400 IM
 - (C) 200 fly
 - (D) 100 free

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Positive:** Koby's fast times prove that young athletes can compete at a high level, and he inspires other swimmers to work hard and aim for their goals.
2. **Critical:** There can be a lot of pressure on a teenager to keep breaking records, and some worry that he might burn out before reaching his full potential.
3. **Neutral:** While his personal bests are impressive, he will face even faster swimmers at the Australian Trials, so his biggest tests are still ahead.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):